

One for the album: From (L-R): Rajesh Ramesh, Muhammed Ajmal, Amoj Jacob and Muhammed Anas celebrate qualifying for the men's 4x400m relay final at the World Athletics Championships. GETTY IMAGES

I, for instance, were keen on witnessing the Northern Lights. However, with only a few weeks off, we opted for a brief getaway to Goa."

The rest of the team swiftly concluded its vacation plans. Anas, the eldest member at 29 and the lead runner, says, "We mainly visited our families, and then the coach emphasised the need to resume training, so that's what we did."

Despite the lack of a cooling-off period, there were no complaints. The team had realised its capabilities over the course of the season. Amoj, 25 and the second oldest in the squad, running the second leg, reflects, "Last year was a bit of a roller coaster. We had some really good achievements at the Worlds, and then we ended with a high at the Asian Games. But as much as there is this recognition, it comes with pressure because it's an Olympic year."

Making it to Paris is not as significant as the team's belief in what it can achieve there. "We truly believe this team can be on the Olympic podium. We believe we can create history. The team is committed to reaching the podium," Amoj says.

The 2023 World Championships in Budapest unlocked this belief, according to Amoj. During the heats, the Indian relay team ran its first-ever sub-three-minute race. In the final lap, Rajesh even appeared to take the lead against track giant USA before finishing a remarkable second.

The next day, they proved that their heats wasn't a lucky one-off by covering the length under three minutes again before finishing fifth.

"I wasn't in the race myself, but after that race, it seemed like everyone was cheering for us," says William. "The Netherlands team approached us. We could see the Kenyans, Jamaicans, and Americans

cheering for us. They were all used to winning among themselves. Now, they were seeing someone else. Everyone loves an underdog, right?" he says.

They now believed in their potential, just as their rivals did.

"If there's one thing that we learned last year, it's that the whole game at the elite level is about mindset," says Amoj. "Honestly, before last year, we didn't have it. We were competing on the world stage with the best athletes, but we didn't believe we were one of them. We were training for the Worlds, but in our hearts, we didn't believe that we were at that level. Now, we believe we are capable of winning in the Olympics. There is a change in mindset. Anything is possible. That is the key factor that is going to change for us," he says.

Even though the team finished out of the medals, they rate their performance in Budapest better than that at the Asian Games, where they coasted to a gold medal. "At the start of the year, we were focussing on the World Championships. We didn't think too much about the Asian Games. That was easy. We just wanted to have a good time at the World Championships, and we did it," says Anas.

And while its Asian record time of 2:59.05 might have been one of the highlights of Indian track history, the team believes it can go even faster.

"Last year, we could have run a time of 2:58 if we had made fewer mistakes. In the final, one of us got blocked, another got pushed, and we still ran under three minutes. Even in the heats, where we set an Asian record, I don't think we ran a perfect race. It was our best race, but lots of things could have been better," says Amoj.

He points to the last lap, where Rajesh looked like he was about to overtake Justin Robinson of the USA in the first bend. "That was when Rajesh got pushed. When we see the race, it's nice to see an Indian guy leading, but you don't want to go in front so early. You want to be behind your opponent, so at the last stretch, you have enough energy to go around him and to the front. If that happened, then we would almost surely have run 2:58.00," says Amoj.

Amoj believes that his teammates are capable of running a potential time in the 2:58.00 range, which could help them secure a podium finish in Paris. To provide some perspective, the bronze medallist in the 2008 Olympics completed the race in 2:58.81; in 2012 it was 2:59.40; and in 2016 it was 2:58.49.

"We could have run in the 2:58.00 range last year as well, but this time we are trying to be optimistic and are trying for something in the 2:57.00 range. It's a very difficult target, but even if we don't get there; if we push hard enough, we should at least get

